Great Escapes

By David Susman

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Everyone wants to believe that they will age well -- that dementia, broken hips, and other debilitating elements of aging will not happen to them.*
ACTOR: *But when family members can no longer care for loved ones at home, assisted living is an option that many choose.*
ACTRESS: *Let's just say, Lorraine isn't accepting this option without a fight*
ACTOR: *Or actually . . . a "flight" . . . a "prison break" . . . One of those . . .*
TOGETHER: *Great Escapes by David Susman.*

(Pg 91-98) *FRED's house; evening. An empty living room, not particularly stylish or ornate. The doorbell rings. After a beat, it rings again ... several times, with urgency. FRED enters from the bedroom.*

FRED: Okay, okay ... *(When he opens the door, LORRAINE bursts in. She uses a walker and clearly has limited mobility, but she moves with surprising speed and buzzes with energy.)*

LORRAINE: Thank God you're here! I was afraid I was going to have to hide in the bushes until you got home!

FRED: *(Amazed to see her.)* Jesus! Mom, what are you-?

LORRAINE: Close the door! They're probably out there right now, looking for me.

FRED: Who?

LORRAINE: Don't think they won't come after me, either. Ohhhh, they'll be plenty mad when they figure it out!

FRED: Who's looking-? Is everything all right? Mom, how did you even get here?

LORRAINE: By the skin of my teeth, that's how! Two taxis, three different buses... you have to keep switching, to make sure you're not being followed ... Close the door, Fred! ... Do you want me to get caught?

FRED: *(Closing the door.)* I don't understand ... what's going on? Caught by who?

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LORRAINE: Them. You think they'll sit idly by while one of their inmates has escaped? Believe me, they'll be out in full force, scouring the streets.

FRED: Mom, I don't know what you're talking about, but you shouldn't be riding the bus by yourself, especially at this time of night. Or taking taxis. I mean, with your hip, just getting in and out of them. *(Beat.)* What do you mean, "escaped"?

LORRAINE: Escaped. Busted out. Made a break for it. Liberated myself from that gulag you and your brother put me in.

FRED: Shady Meadows isn't a gulag, Mom. It's an assisted-living facility, and a very nice one. Are you saying you left without telling anyone?

LORRAINE: Tell anyone? It was all I could do to avoid detection. There were some close calls, but so far I've managed to stay one step ahead.

FRED: Christ! You know you're not supposed to leave the grounds without notifying them. They must be worried sick!

LORRAINE: The only thing they're worried about is recapturing me. But that's not going to happen. See, I've got it all worked out. I'll lay low for a few hours, then after dark I'll make my way to the train station. It's safer than the airport. Now, they'll be expecting me to head south, to Mexico ... so I'll head north, to Canada.

FRED: Are you nuts?! You can't go to Canada.

LORRAINE: Not to live, obviously. Just to throw the authorities off my trail. I'll hide out there until the heat is off, then I'll cross back into the States and work my way to the Rockies. I'll lay low in your brother's ski cabin until I can figure out my next move.

FRED: Mom, I don't know what's gotten into you, but you can't go traipsing all over North America. And you can't leave Shady Meadows without telling them! They were very explicit about that when we moved you in, remember? No

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leaving the building unaccompanied. It's for your own safety. You could be in a lot of trouble for this. They could evict you and we could lose our entire deposit.

LORRAINE: You seem stressed. Did I come at a bad time? Were you and Samantha in the middle of something?

FRED: Samantha's not here, Mom. And no, you didn't...I just don't understand what's going on. Why in the world would you want to leave Shady Meadows?

LORRAINE: To taste freedom, Fred! To throw off the shackles of oppression and feel the wind in my hair!

FRED: What oppression? Shady Meadows is perfectly nice. Beautiful grounds, kind staff, all sorts of activities.

LORRAINE: Are you kidding? The place is a prison. Eat when they tell you, sleep when they tell you, play games when they tell you. It's a penal colony!

FRED: Penal colonies don't have canasta, Mom.

LORRAINE: They thought they could tame me, break my spirit. But they underestimated me... that was their big mistake.

FRED: No one's trying to break your spirit. A few rules, that's all. No cooking in the rooms. No loud music after ten. No leaving the building without checking out at the front. (Beat.) Wait a minute. How did you get past the front desk? Isn't there supposed to be an attendant there at all times?

LORRAINE: You mean Burt the Jailkeeper? He was there, all right. Believe me, it took plenty of planning to figure out a way around him.

FRED: I don't understand ... you snuck past the attendant?

LORRAINE: Well, I hardly had to sneak. He was distracted by all the smoke. **FRED:** What smoke?

LORRAINE: From the fire.

FRED: What fire?!

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LORRAINE: The one in the television lounge. It's a classic diversionary technique. Ever read The Art of War by Sun Tzu?

FRED: You started a big fire?!

LORRAINE: Of course not. Do you think I'm a maniac? Of course, I didn't start a big fire. *(Beat.)* I started a small fire.

FRED: Jesus Christ! Was anyone hurt?

LORRAINE: Don't be ridiculous...it was a controlled burn. I knew the lounge would be empty that time of night, so I just gathered some Popsicle sticks from the crafts room, added a few pine cones and a little rolled-up newspaper, and lit it in that hideous ceramic urn they keep in there.

FRED: Mom, someone could have been killed!

LORRAINE: Oh, please ... I've seen bigger flames on a plate of fajitas. But the smoke, that was the real intimidation factor. The trick there is, I added some of Eunice's hair spray. The chemicals darken up the smoke, make it look like a real inferno.

FRED: Your roommate was in on this?

LORRAINE: Well, she was more of what you'd call an unknowing participant. I knew she'd never approve, so I waited until she was asleep, then I helped myself to her toiletries and stole into the night.

FRED: But you always said she was such a light sleeper.

LORRAINE: She is, generally. But tonight there may have been a little extra sedative in her orange juice.

FRED: You drugged Mrs. McClusky?!

LORRAINE: No, I didn't drug her. Am I crazy? I don't go around drugging my friends. *(Beat.)* I drugged her a little bit.

FRED: Mom! Do you have any idea how dangerous that it?

LORRAINE: Trust me, she's fine. She's getting the best night's sleep she's had in years.

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I gave her the good stuff ... took it right from Doctor Adelman's private stash.

FRED: You stole drugs from the medical office?!

LORRAINE: Well, they practically leave the cabinet wide open. It only took a few minutes to pick the lock with a toothbrush and a bobby pin.

FRED: This is insanity! You can't go around wreaking havoc. And you can't leave Shady Meadows. It took a lot of work to find a place that you'd be comfortable and safe, and all you had to do was...was...be normal. Make friends... enjoy some quiet pastimes ... not run around waging guerilla warfare!

LORRAINE: You're awfully tense. Are you sure I didn't interrupt something? Maybe you and Samantha were having relations?

FRED: No, Mom, we weren't-

LORRAINE: Because I know how frustrating it can be when you're in the middle of coitus, and you have to stop and-

FRED: We weren't. Samantha doesn't live here anymore, Mom. We split up, remember?

LORRAINE: Of course, I remember. I just thought she might still be coming by for the occasional playtime. Women have needs, you know.

FRED: Can we just get back to?

LORRAINE: Especially that one. She may have been a little quiet, but underneath I could tell she was a hotsy-totsy. It's a shame you couldn't hold on to her.

FRED: *(Wearily.)* Yes, I know.

LORRAINE: Was it the money? Is that why she left? Because I always said, if you just asserted yourself at work a little more, that boss of yours would stop passing you over.

FRED: It wasn't money.

LORRAINE: *(Looking FRED up and down contemplatively.)* Maybe the way you dress. You've

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always been a little drab-looking, dear. You know, ladies like a man with some panache.

FRED: That's not why she left. I don't know why she left. She just said, "I need something else" and moved out.

LORRAINE: Well, did you ask what the something else was?

FRED: She didn't take follow-up questions. I got home, her things were packed, and she was halfway out the door. That was it. "I need something else."

LORRAINE: It's a pity, is all. You've always had such a difficult time with women. Now, your brother, he has to fight 'em off with a stick. A new one every week, it seems. Real lookers, too. Of course, women go for adventurous men like Hank. Skiing, rock climbing, skydiving ... roaming from town to town, wherever the wind takes him. That's some life he leads!

FRED: *(Unenthusiastically.)* He's quite a fellow, yes.

LORRAINE: Maybe he could give you a few pointers. About women. I could ask him when I see him.

FRED: I don't need any advice from Tarzan, thank you. And you can't go trekking into the Rockies to find him.

LORRAINE: Of course I can. You think I don't know how to use a compass?

FRED: Mom, you have a bad hip...you have arthritis and neuropathy ... you take five different medications before breakfast. You need care. And despite what you've been telling yourself, Shady Meadows is not Shawshank Prison. It's a pleasant and clean and well-run facility ... assuming it's still standing.

LORRAINE: If you think it's so wonderful, why don't you go live there?

FRED: I would if I could. At least I'd be a well-behaved resident.

LORRAINE: You're a well-behaved everything, Fred. That's your problem. You're a rule follower. You always have been. You're diligent, polite, considerate. You don't cheat on your taxes. You drive the speed limit. You eat sensibly. You don't

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curse or chase women or embezzle money or get arrested for drunken disorderliness.

FRED: How ashamed of me you must be.

LORRAINE: I'm just saying, a little misbehavior would do you good.

FRED: We can't all be lunatics, Mom. We can't all go around setting fires and drugging our friends. Someone has to be responsible. Someone has to hold it all together.

LORRAINE: And where has it gotten you? Tell me that, Fred. What has all that good behavior done for you?

FRED: What's it done for me? I'll tell you what it's done for me: nothing! It's gotten me nowhere! I have no girlfriend and no money. I have a lousy job and an ungrateful boss. You think I don't want to be wild and cause trouble? You think I don't want to buck the system? Well, I can't. I have obligations. Shady Meadows costs money. You know where it comes from? The lousy job with the ungrateful boss! And who found you Shady Meadows in the first place? Who does everything for you, while Hank is off playing Hugh Hefner on ice? Me! Always me, Mom. While everyone else is having adventures and breaking away and escaping to new, wonderful lives, I'm just here. Where's my great escape, Mom? When do I get to break away?

LORRAINE: I didn't know you wanted to.

FRED: Well, I do. This isn't the life I was supposed to have. This isn't who I was supposed to be.

LORRAINE: Then be someone else.

FRED: I don't know how. I'm not like you and Hank and Samantha. I'm just... Fred. I'm drably dressed, underpaid, unadventurous Fred. *(Beat.)* How do you do it? How do you be...the way you are? Breaking the rules. Rebelling against everything. Taking all those risks.

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LORRAINE: I had no choice. You and your brother stuck me in the Black Hole of Calcutta. *(Beat; off FRED's look.)* I got old, Fred. When you get old, you run out of options. Everything becomes boring and safe. You realize the only excitement you'll ever have is if you make it yourself. The world isn't interested in making it for you. Not anymore. You want my advice? Don't get old. I hope you never do, Fred.

FRED: I already feel old.

LORRAINE: You're not. You don't have to be. You can change. You can be a whole different Fred, if that's what you want. Don't change too much, though. I like my Fred. He's kind and decent. He has a good heart. The world needs that. I need that. Even if I don't always say thank you. *(Beat.)* I have to go back to Shady Meadows, don't I?

FRED: Is it that bad?

LORRAINE: No. That's the problem. *(FRED grabs his jacket, keys.)*

FRED: Come on. I'll drive you. We'll smooth things over with the management. *(They start to exit, FRED helping LORRAINE along.)*

LORRAINE: You know, Eunice has a daughter. Divorced. I met her once. A terrible dresser, just like you. You two might hit it off.

FRED: We'll see, Mom. We'll take it one step at a time.

LORRAINE: She's not ready to date either. But in case you want it, I have her phone number.

FRED: Why did Mrs. McClusky give it to you, if she's not ready to date?

LORRAINE: Well, she didn't exactly give it to me...

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Susman
Book: The Best New Ten-Minute Plays 2019, Pg 91-98
ISBN: 978-1493053179
Publisher: Applause
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2019

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